10/21 WEDNESDAY — STORY OUTLINE

Airdate: Wednesday, October 21, 2026 (F2, taped) · **Stories:** A + B + C, approved by the producer 10/13 (jeff_approval.md) · **Guest:** Lon Seidman, tech reviewer, Lon.TV (A story) · **Sponsor:** OmniWatch (2 breaks) · **Stage:** beats

RUNNING ORDER

Slot	What	Weight	Clips
Tease	The TV that watches what you watch, the rental bill with a fake photo, the call that doubles your electric rate	—	—
A	Your TV is watching what you watch: turn this off tonight	~55% of show	4
Break	OmniWatch — after A beat 8 (Lon's bottom line)	—	—
B	They're billing you for damage you didn't do	~25%	2
Break	OmniWatch — after B beat 4 (the walkaround)	—	—
C	Winter bills are going up, and this one call can double yours	~20%	2
End	End of show	—	—

Open package: undecided (see Decisions). Recommended: the team's own footage of a TV menu with the tracking setting switched on (A beat 7), not the disputed LG audio clip.

The show in three sentences

Your smart TV checks what's on its screen every few seconds and sells the pattern to advertisers, it's on by default, and only people in Texas were ever asked. A separate investigation says LG sets may record audio in standby, which LG denies, so we keep that claim separate and show you the setting that's proven on every brand. Then a rental host bills a renter for a tire with a photo of a different car, and callers ride this winter's higher bills to switch you to a supplier charging nearly double.

The ride

A climbs from your screen to the ad companies to the claim about your living room, then exhales on a fix any viewer can do with the remote. B is a quick outrage with a satisfying catch: she proved the photo was fake. C starts with a bill everyone dreads and ends on one line to check tonight, so the show exhales twice.

Decisions before we write

- 10/16 F1 collision: the pre-bible recommended the TV story as the 10/16 F1 lead, with winter bills as an F1 option. Confirm neither is running on 10/16.
- Third TV-tracking video (January ~654K, spring ~316K; Ryan says the devices video was a hit). The new angles are the Texas consent deals and the LG claim; the title has to sell one of them.
- Open package: the Gamers Nexus clip is the most dramatic footage but carries the disputed claim. Recommend opening on the team's menu footage (beat 7) and keeping LG to beat 6.
- A beat 7 depends on the team filming real 2026 sets. Which brands can we get? Samsung, LG, Vizio, Roku and Sony cover most homes.
- Fire TV: the Amazon rule is for F1. On this F2, include Fire TV's setting or keep it out?
- A is thin on people: beat 3 has no person yet, and beats 4 to 6 are a creator, a state and a company. Beat 3 (someone finding the setting on their own TV) is the human beat; it needs a name.
- Lon Seidman: confirm booked, and check for sponsor or affiliate ties to TV brands or Roku before he gives settings advice.

- B: no 55+ victim, and both renters were refunded, so there's no real-loss case to lead with. It plays as a warning with a fix.
- B: hotel fees in or out? Recommend out (one Jeff line at most) to keep B to four beats.
- C has no 55+ victim and no clip of the call yet; beat 3 has no person. Without a find, C is Jeff, one news clip and a bill on screen.
- C savings guide: how much? Recommend three lines (check your supply rate, budget billing, LIHEAP), all sourced.

A. YOUR TV IS WATCHING WHAT YOU WATCH: TURN THIS OFF TONIGHT

In one sentence: Smart TVs check what's on screen every few seconds and sell that data to advertisers, it's on by default, only Texans got asked, and one setting turns it off.

Hold back: the setting's name on each brand and where it hides in the menu.

Peg: Texas forced Samsung (Feb 2026) and LG (May 2026) to ask before tracking → but only in Texas → everyone else is still opted in and was never asked. "Texas got asked. You didn't." Plus the Gamers Nexus investigation (Sept 7) that put TV spying back in the news.

Framing: your smart TV, whatever the brand, on by default.

Climb: closer and closer to you: what's on your screen → who buys it → what the TV might hear in the room (disputed) → you take it back.

Weight: ~55% of show · 4 clip beats

#	Beat	Who	What happens	Clip
1	The hook	You (the viewer)	Every show you watch, even a DVD or a cable box, your smart TV checks what's on the screen.	JEFF
2	It's watching	Lon Seidman, tech reviewer, Lon.TV	The feature is called ACR: snapshots of the screen matched to a database, on by default; one 2024 study clocked LG about every 15 seconds.	GUEST
3	She finds it on	Unnamed — need a name (TV owner, 2026)	A TV owner opens her settings on camera and finds the tracking switched on.	FIND · VERTICAL — TikTok/Reels of an owner finding ACR on
4	Who's buying	She Prepares, older-audience creator (Oct 2026)	Her video on Walmart and LG TVs and the ad business behind the screen.	HAVE · HORIZONTAL — She Prepares 6WT5fc-LHSc
5	Only Texas got asked	Texas Attorney General's office (Dec 2025 – May 2026)	Texas sued TV makers; Samsung and LG agreed to ask Texans first, and nobody else.	FIND · HORIZONTAL — Texas TV news on the AG suits or settlements
6	The claim LG denies	Steve Burke, Gamers Nexus (Sept 2026)	His investigation alleges LG sets recorded room audio in standby; LG says the claims are not true.	HAVE · HORIZONTAL — Gamers Nexus 6IFVTcM28KA
7	Turn it off, brand by brand	You (the viewer)	The team films the menus on real sets; Jeff narrates the path for Samsung, LG, Vizio, Roku and Sony.	DEMO
8	Lon's bottom line	Lon Seidman	The TV keeps working with it off, ads just get less targeted, plus the microphone setting worth checking.	GUEST

The fix

- After Lon (beat 2): an ad for something you just watched on another channel is ACR at work.
- After She Prepares (beat 4): if your TV asked you to "agree" to anything at setup, assume the tracking is on.
- After Gamers Nexus (beat 6): don't wait for the listening claim to be settled; turn off what's proven.
- Samsung: Viewing Information Services, off (Consumer Reports, how to turn off smart TV snooping, updated 10/19/2025). ⚠️ verify on a 2026 set.
- LG: Viewing Information (Live Plus), off (Consumer Reports). ⚠️ verify on a 2026 set.

- Vizio: Viewing Data, off (Consumer Reports). ⚠️ verify on a 2026 set.
- Roku TVs: Use Info from TV Inputs, off (Consumer Reports). ⚠️ verify on a 2026 set.
- Sony: Samba Interactive TV, off (Consumer Reports). ⚠️ verify on a 2026 set.
- Microphone: Roku, Microphone Access to Never Allow; Samsung's physical mic switch. ⚠️ unsourced, verify on the sets.
- Do-nothing test: do nothing and the tracking stays on; turning it off doesn't break the TV (Consumer Reports). ⚠️ Check whether a software update or factory reset turns it back on; if so, add "check again after updates."
- The one setting the tease promises is ACR, under each brand's name above (Consumer Reports).

Gaps

- ⚠️ Beat 3: no person yet. If the search comes back empty, beat 3 folds into Jeff and the demo.
- ⚠️ Beat 5: the Texas suits are Dec 2025 and Samsung's deal Feb 2026, more than six months before airdate. Date them on air ("last December," "in February").
- ⚠️ Beat 2: the IMC study is 2024. Date it on air.
- ⚠️ Beat 4: She Prepares' content is known from its title only; what it says about Walmart and LG is unconfirmed until the transcript.
- ⚠️ Beats 4 and 6 are creator videos, so they need clearance. No local news clip on this story is over 200K.

Jeff should know

- Beat 6: LG says the claims "are not true," and nothing independent has confirmed them. Never say "LG is listening"; say "the investigation alleges." Gamers Nexus also posted a follow-up, "LG Says We're Fake News" (~3.9M).
- Beat 5: the Texas deals cover Texans only. Viewers elsewhere have to switch the setting off themselves.
- Beat 4: the 49 million US LG TVs figure is LG Ad Solutions' own number.
- Beat 2: the every-15-seconds figure is one 2024 study of LG sets, not every brand.
- Beat 7: Fire TV is out unless the room says otherwise (see Decisions).

B. THEY'RE BILLING YOU FOR DAMAGE YOU DIDN'T DO

In one sentence: A Turo host billed a Utah renter for smoking and a ruined tire, she proved his tire photo was an old picture of a different car, and it's not the only case.

Hold back: the tire in the "proof" photo wasn't her car; it was a years-old picture from Reddit.

Peg: KSL's report (Oct 5) is doing 547K in five days, and holiday travel is weeks out (AAA: 81.8M Thanksgiving travelers in 2025). "Your phone is your alibi."

Framing: a damage bill that shows up after you've returned the car.

Climb: a charge you can't argue with → the proof is fake → the host says he's filed thousands of tire claims, and it's happening elsewhere.

Weight: ~25% of show · 2 clip beats

#	Beat	Who	What happens	Clip
1	The bill	Hope Orr, Draper, Utah (Oct 2026)	After returning a Turo rental she's billed $165 for smoking, and Turo warns a $500 tire charge is coming.	HAVE · HORIZONTAL — KSL Get Gephardt 1_wUVS5szfw
2	The photo was fake	Hope Orr (Oct 2026)	A reverse image search finds the tire photo on Reddit, years old, a different car; Turo bans the host and refunds her.	HAVE · HORIZONTAL — KSL, same clip (second segment)
3	It's not just one host	Georgina Montalvan, Birmingham (July 2026)	She's billed $2,338 for damage her own pickup photos show was already there, and refunded after a columnist steps in.	JEFF
4	Your phone is your alibi	You (the viewer)	Jeff films a slow walkaround of a rental, tires and interior, and runs a damage photo through a reverse image search.	DEMO

The fix

- After Hope: a damage photo you can't match to your car. Run it through a reverse image search (Google Lens) before you pay. ⚠️ source
- After Georgina: a bill that arrives days later with no itemized estimate. Ask for one in writing.
- Video walkaround of the car, tires and interior at pickup and at drop-off, with the timestamp on. ⚠️ source (Turo trip-photo policy, turo.com)
- Dispute through the platform, never "settle direct" with a host. ⚠️ source (Turo help pages)
- Still charged? Dispute it with your card company. ⚠️ source (CFPB)

Gaps

- ⚠️ Both renters were refunded and neither is confirmed 55+. No real-loss case.
- ⚠️ Beat 3 is print only (Elliott Report / Boston Globe); no video expected.
- ⚠️ The KSL article doesn't say "4-year-old" photo; say "years-old."

Jeff should know

- Beat 2: "more than 5,000 tire claims in the last nine years" is the host's own claim to KSL. Don't name the host.
- Beat 3: Montalvan's rental company isn't confirmed as Turo; keep it "a renter in Birmingham."
- Hotel fees: the FTC rule since May 2025 says mandatory resort fees must be in the total price, if the room keeps a line on it.

C. WINTER BILLS ARE GOING UP, AND THIS ONE CALL CAN DOUBLE YOURS

In one sentence: Winter heating bills are rising, and callers claiming to be from your utility's "price protection program" switch you to a supplier charging nearly double.

Hold back: the "price protection" offer is the trap: saying yes is what doubles your rate.

Peg: EIA's winter outlook (Oct 6) says electric-heat homes pay about 4% more and heating-oil homes about 21% more → people are already worried about the bill → a call offering to "lock in" a rate sounds like help. "The bill is real. The program isn't."

Framing: a phone call about your electric bill from someone who says they're with your utility.

Climb: your bill goes up → someone offers to protect you → the protection nearly doubles it.

Weight: ~20% of show · 2 clip beats

#	Beat	Who	What happens	Clip
1	The bill goes up	You (the viewer)	Electric-heat homes will pay about 4% more this winter and heating-oil homes about 21% more (EIA, Oct 6).	JEFF
2	Her bill nearly tripled	Manassas, Virginia homeowner, unnamed (Jan 2026)	Her January bill jumps from about $100 to $281.	FIND · HORIZONTAL — local news on a Manassas or Virginia bill spike
3	The call	Unnamed — need a name (Illinois customer, 2026)	A caller claims a utility "price protection program," and the customer is enrolled with Rushmore Energy at nearly double the rate.	FIND · HORIZONTAL — Illinois news on the AG's Rushmore settlement or a switched customer
4	Check this line tonight	You (the viewer)	A real bill on screen: find "supply" or "price to compare," and call your utility if you don't recognize the company.	DEMO

The fix

- After the homeowner: a bill that jumps with no change in use. Check who your supplier is before anything else.
- After the call: your utility won't call to "lock" your rate. Hang up and call the number on your bill.
- Find the supplier and "price to compare" lines on your bill. ⚠️ source (state utility commission page; the term varies by state)
- Never give your account number to a caller (Illinois Attorney General, Rushmore Energy settlement, 6/4/2026). ⚠️ confirm the AG's page says it
- Budget billing to spread winter costs (your utility). ⚠️ source
- LIHEAP for help paying heating bills, through your state. ⚠️ verify 2026–27 funding (acf.hhs.gov)
- Do-nothing test: if you were already switched, doing nothing keeps you on the higher rate. Call your utility to switch back, and ask about cancellation fees. ⚠️ source

Gaps

- ⚠️ No 55+ victim and no clip of the call. Beat 3 may end up a news clip about the settlement, not a person.
- ⚠️ C2 Manassas bill is January 2026 (Consumer Reports, March): date it on air ("last January").
- ⚠️ Supplier switching only exists in states with retail choice. The tell has to work for viewers everywhere.

Jeff should know

- Beat 3: the Rushmore matter is a settlement of the Illinois AG's allegations; "nearly double" is the AG's wording. ⚠️ Check whether Rushmore admitted anything.
- Beat 1: don't say data centers doubled bills. Leave data centers out.
- Beat 4: in states without supplier choice there's no supply company to switch, and a call like this is a scam outright.